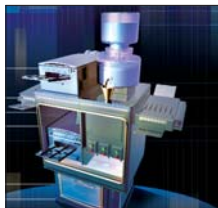


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Be The Game

From playing games to creating them... level up!

Samir Makwana

If you've seen the best real-time strategy games like *Warcraft III*, thrilling first-person shooters such as *Half-Life*, and have had multiplayer fun with *Counter-Strike* and *Quake 3 Arena*, you love them. Have you ever, though, given a serious thought towards actually making a game? Will it fetch you money, fame, and success? It can. A career in games is a lucrative option.

Gaming is a no more a niche market. According to the latest reports from IDC India, India is one of the fastest growing markets for computers. Here, the PC ownership ratio is 1:50, amounting to 22 million installations. In the past five to six years, India has grown as a potential market for the global game development biggies.

The Internet and Mobile Association of India recently conducted a study on online gaming. It found that the online gaming industry here is worth Rs 210 crore. The study also found that youth in the age group of 17 to 25 years are the key drivers of the online gaming segment. Yet, the industry faces issues—high cost of enabling proper infrastructures in accordance with international standards, recognition and support of game develop-

ment and related courses, and negative perception among parents.

"The global game development market is expected to grow to \$42 billion (Rs 1.9 lakh crore) by 2010 from \$21 billion in 2006—a CAGR (Compound Annual Growth Rate) of 18 per cent. India is becoming an outsourcing hub for animation and game design and development," says Raman Madan, regional manager—Media and Entertainment Software (APAC), AutoDesk, who are into the business of software technologies for the simulation, animation, media, and entertainment domains.

Since 2002, game development in India has picked up. Earlier, a number of India-based studios and companies were involved in developing and testing game projects for companies in the west. But in the past few years, gaming behemoths like Electronic Arts, Gameloft, and FXLabs, along with the Indian players like Jump Games, Dhruva Interactive, Trine Game Studios, Lakshya Digital, Game Shastra, and others have been active in the game business in India.

"The Indian gaming industry is fairly nascent, and immense opportunities are available for game

